

## User Stories For Features:

- 1. Login & Logout:** Login should be prompted upon reaching the site/opening the app. Account creation should be available from the login page so new users can easily create an account. Users should be able to log in using their email/username and password. A token/session system should be implemented while the user is logged in. Logout should be easily accessible at all times. When a user logs out, the active token/session should be invalidated or cleared so protected PondLite features require login again. Accounts should persist after application closure and retain information related to that account. Passwords should be securely hashed before being stored. Accounts should also have a manage/settings feature to allow user preferences, display names, and other account-level settings to be updated.
- 2. Daily Emotional Check-In:** When accessing the Pond page/tab, the user should be prompted for their daily check-in if they have not checked in for that day. The user should be prompted with an emotion wheel to help them decide how they are feeling. The user should be able to select up to three emotions, but only one should be required to complete the check-in. These emotions should be stored as primary, secondary, and tertiary emotions. The user should also have the option to include a message for their PondMate. This message should be displayed to the PondMate when they enter the Pond or view the check-in. The message should remain private to the shared Pond. The check-in should update the user's frog state for the day. If a user has not completed their check-in, their frog should appear asleep or inactive. Check-ins should reset each day, but previous check-ins may be retained for history, reflection, or Smart Connection Assistant context.
- 3. Daily Relationship-Oriented Discussion:** The system should provide an optional daily relationship-oriented discussion prompt. This prompt should appear above or near the Pond. PondMates should be able to select the prompt and post a reply. Responses should be saved and available to view later, but only if the user submits a response. Participation should be optional and should not punish users for skipping a prompt. Discussion prompts may be generated by AI or selected from a stored prompt list. AI-generated prompts should be gentle, low-pressure, and appropriate for the emotional tone of the app. Prompt generation may be adjusted based on feedback, recent participation, or relationship context. Discussion responses should remain private to the shared Pond.
- 4. Ribbits / Gentle Reminders:** PondLite should include a Ribbit feature for small messages, gentle reminders, care offers, or lightweight requests between PondMates. Ribbits should feel softer than tasks and should support the app's low-pressure design. A Ribbit can be one of several types, such as: Thought, Gentle Request, Care Offer, or Task. The receiving PondMate should be able to acknowledge a Ribbit with an emoji, such as a heart, thumbs-up, or other gentle response. If the Ribbit is a task or request, the receiving PondMate should be able to mark it as completed or rejected. The sender should be able to see the acknowledgement, completion, or rejection status. The sender should also be able to cancel/delete a Ribbit they created. Ribbits should only be visible to the two PondMates in the shared Pond.

5. **Bug-Themed Gift System:** Each user should have a stash of bugs tracked by the system. Bugs are a lightweight reward currency used to feed or gift the other frog. A bug may be rewarded to each user when both PondMates complete their daily check-in. Bugs should be used for playful connection rather than pressure. The user should be able to spend a bug to feed their PondMate's frog, and the receiving PondMate should be able to see that their frog was fed. Bug rewards should support the feeling that both users are caring for the Pond together.
6. **Frog Reactivity and Emotional Reflection:** Each PondMate should have a frog displayed in the Pond. Frogs should appear on the Pond screen and visually reflect each user's current emotional state based on their most recent daily check-in. If a user has not completed their check-in for the day, their frog should appear asleep or inactive. If the frog receives a bug gift or feeding from the other PondMate, it should show a heart or similar visual reaction. If there is an unacknowledged Ribbit from the other PondMate, the frog may display a small chat bubble or notification indicator. Frogs should reset to a sleep/inactive state each day until the user completes a new check-in. Frogs should be nameable and should act as emotional avatars for each PondMate.
7. **Smart Connection Assistant:** There should be an integrated AI feature that helps users connect in small, low-pressure ways. The AI should use limited relationship context, such as the user's current mood, their PondMate's current mood, recent check-ins, unanswered Ribbits, and recent discussion activity. Based on this context, the AI should generate gentle suggestions, such as: One care action, One possible message to send, One optional discussion prompt.
8. **Private Pond / Relationship Space:** Each couple should share a private relationship space. In the backend/domain model, this space is represented as a Relationship. In the user interface, this relationship space is called a Pond. Each user connected to a Pond is a PondMate. A user should only be able to view, create, update, or interact with data that belongs to a Pond they are a member of. Private relationship data should not be visible to users outside of that Pond. The Pond should store relationship-specific content, including daily check-ins, frog states, ribbits, discussion prompts, responses, bug rewards, and Smart Connection Assistant suggestions. The AI should not make decisions for the user, send messages automatically, pressure either person to act, or present itself as relationship counseling. It should function as optional support for users who want help knowing what to say, how to respond, or how to show care. The user should be able to accept, ignore, or regenerate suggestions. AI suggestions should remain private to the requesting user unless the user chooses to send or act on them. The AI should only receive the minimum context needed to generate useful suggestions.
9. **PondMate Connection / Invitation:** A user should be able to connect with one PondMate to create or join a shared Pond. If a user does not have a connected PondMate, the Pond page should display a message explaining that no PondMate is connected yet. The system should eventually provide a way to invite or connect with a PondMate. For early development, this connection may be created manually or through a simplified process. Later versions can include a more formal invitation flow. Once two users are connected to the same Pond, they should be able to see shared Pond content

and interact with each other through check-ins, ribbits, discussion prompts, gifts, and frog reactions.

10. **Pond Rhythm Rewards:** PondLite may eventually include soft consistency rewards.

These rewards should not be framed as traditional streaks that reset to zero or punish users for missing a day. Instead, the system may use gentle language such as Pond Rhythm, Pond Activity, or Shared Rhythm. Rewards may include bonus bugs, small visual flair, or flavor text when both PondMates have been active recently. The system should avoid shame, pressure, loss of progress, or guilt-based language. Missing a day should not cause punishment, decay, or negative feedback.